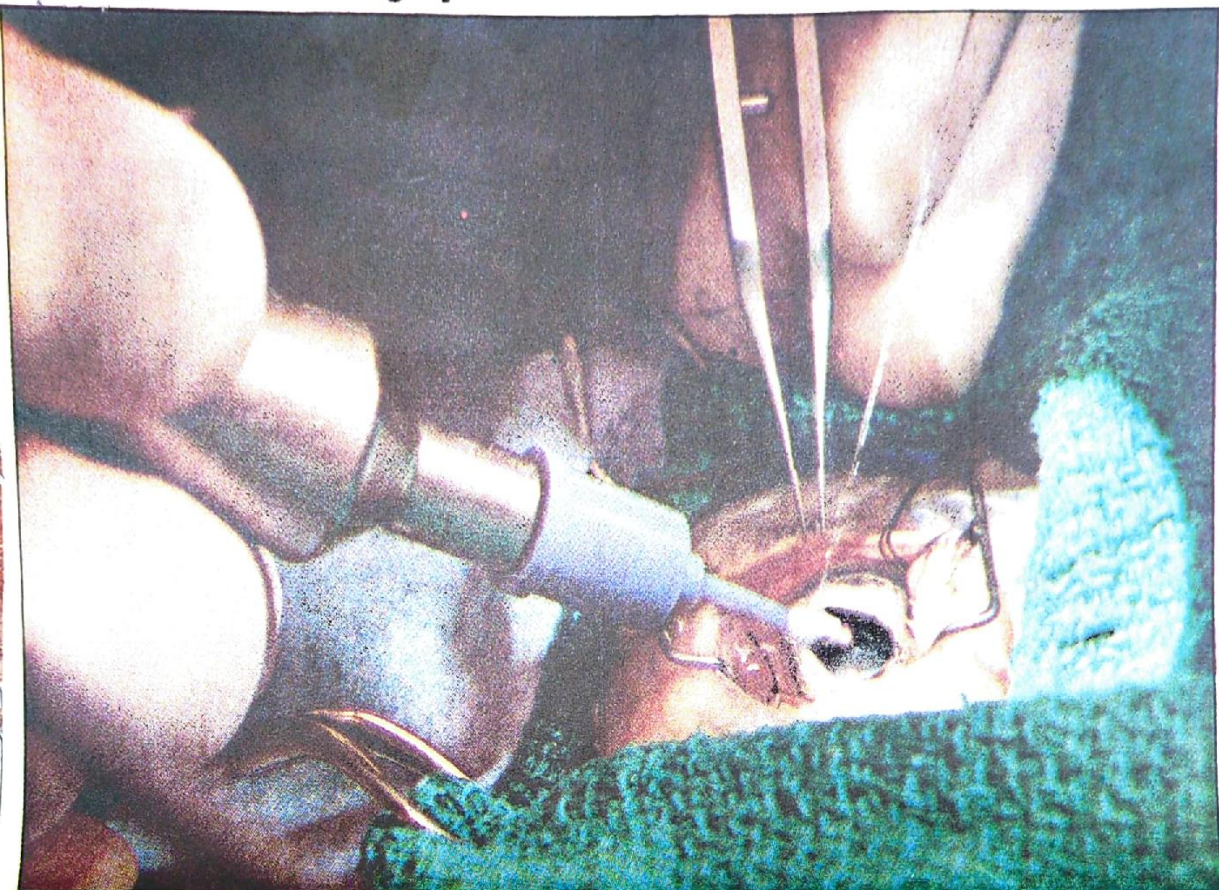


Bird's eye view of surgery



Photos by GARY O'BRIEN/Staff

A veterinary ophthalmologist uses a vacuum probe to draw the pieces of cloudy cataract out of an American bald eagle's eye. Lancelot, the 7-pound bird, is the world's first American bald

eagle to undergo such surgery. The cataract had left Lancelot half-blind and flying in circles, unable to be shown off to raptor center visitors.

Cataracts history for American bald eagle

By KEN GARFIELD
Staff Writer

Lying still on a stainless steel surgical table Friday, Lancelot the American bald eagle didn't exactly portray a powerful symbol of America.

Instead, the 7-pound patient with the bum left eye played the lead role in a bit of medical history.

With Charlotte veterinary ophthalmologist Jesse Eichenbaum cracking jokes as he removed the damaged lens, Lancelot apparently became the world's first American bald eagle to undergo cataract surgery.

For the medical record, about 332,000 humans and 32,500 animals (mostly dogs) undergo cataract surgery each year in the United States.

Back home at the Carolina Raptor Center near Huntersville, the trailblazer with the 6½-foot wingspan is eating white rats and seeing

"It's a beautiful bird. A beautiful bird. . . . He'll be able to see well at a distance, certainly better than he had before."

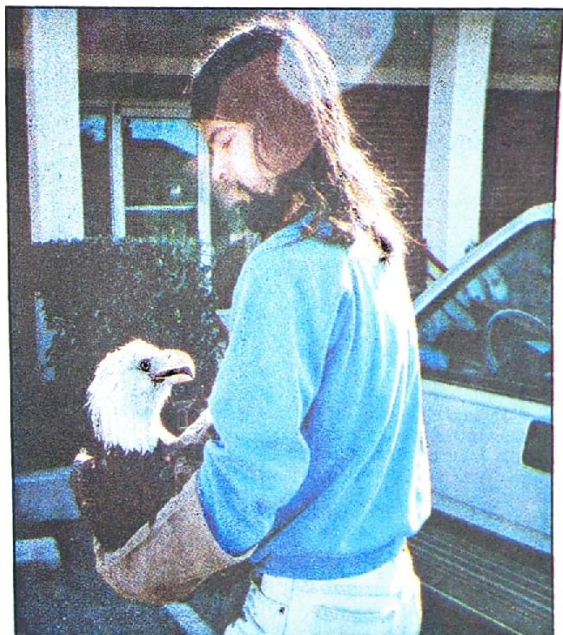
— Jesse Eichenbaum, veterinary ophthalmologist

out of an eye that had long ago gone blind.

Back to performing cataract surgery on dogs in his Elizabeth Avenue office, Eichenbaum, 39, is thrilled he got the veterinary chance of a lifetime.

"These are magnificent birds," said Eichenbaum, whose office didn't charge for the operation. "They're under such pressure from loss of habitat and people shooting

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Winged patient: Mathias Englemann of the Carolina Raptor Center carries a not-so-happy Lancelot to the Elizabeth Avenue office of Charlotte veterinary ophthalmologist Jesse Eichenbaum.

Bird

Eagle makes history with cataract surgery

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them. I get so much out of nature. I feel good I can give something back."

Since he was found shot and starving on the Outer Banks, Lancelot has lived the good life at the raptor center at Latta Plantation Park, which is dedicated to caring for birds of prey.

Lancelot is one of about 5,000 American bald eagles living in the United States. Listed as an endangered species, the birds are off-limits to hunters.

Lancelot's cataract had left him half-blind and flying in circles, unable to be shown off to raptor center visitors. That's how the 5- to 6-year-old eagle wound up Friday with a cone over his beak as anesthesia knocked him out for 65 minutes of ground-breaking surgery.

Surrounded by veterinarians Vivian Jamieson and Rick Beldegreen — plus three helpers and four reporters — Eichenbaum wielded sharp microsurgical instruments. Not to mention a sharp wit.

"You become one with the cataract," said Eichenbaum, taking a deep breath of concentration before covering everything but Lancelot's eye in sterilized towels.

"This is like M*A*S*H," he said as an aide banged on a surgical lamp to get a faulty bulb going.

Then the jokes stopped as Eichenbaum made an incision in Lancelot's cornea, broke the cataract into little pieces and suctioned out the damaged material before closing it with three stitches.

"It's a beautiful bird," said Eichenbaum. "A beautiful bird. The lens was much bigger and deeper than I anticipated. He'll be able to see well at a distance, certainly better than he had before."

When it was over, Carolina Raptor Center officials Mathias Engelmann and Betty O'Leary gently wrapped Lancelot in a Velcro blanket and laid the groggy bird in his cage for the ride home.

O'Leary said she hopes Lancelot will be well enough soon to see visitors regularly.

Eichenbaum — one of 130 veterinary ophthalmologists in North America — hopes he gets a chance to do something this extraordinary again.

"Was I more intense personally?" said Eichenbaum, comparing Lancelot to previous patients. "Yes. You get butterflies in your stomach. It was the unknown of what it was going to be like."

Now, he added, "It's Miller time."

Want to see it?

NBC-TV's "Nightside" and WCNC (channel 36) are scheduled to air footage of Lancelot's cataract surgery next week.